artillery, ships, missiles, equipment and personnel, each ITC is envisioned as a self-contained, integrated formation.

The Indian government has acknowledged that in the era of high-technology, multi-domain warfare, a conflict situation with nuclear-armed adversaries on India's northeastern and northwestern borders—China and Pakistan—would require deft management of military resources that only such jointness could provide. The first debates and plans on theatrisation took place under India's first CDS Gen. Bipin Rawat, and have been firmed up under Gen. Chauhan after he took over as CDS in September 2022.

THE BROAD CONTOURS

After various misgivings from military circles, a broadly accepted plan has evolved. A Western Theatre Command will extend from the Indira Col on Saltoro Ridge of the Siachen Glacier till Gujarat, with its expected headquarters in Jaipur. The Northern Theatre Command will cover the entire 3,488 km of the Line of Actual Control, India's de facto border with China, starting from Karakoram Pass in Ladakh and extending to Kibithu in Arunachal Pradesh. Its headquarters are expected to be in Lucknow. The Maritime Command, based in Thiruvananthapuram, will be responsible for India's 11,098km-long coastline.

Currently, the three services have 17 independent commands: the army and the IAF have seven each and the navy three. India does have unified, tri-services commands—the Port Blair-based Andaman and Nicobar Command, created in 2001, and the Strategic Forces Command in charge of the country's nuclear forces.

Not everyone, however, is in agreement. On August 26, at a seminar at the Army War College in Mhow in Madhya Pradesh, the IAF chief spoke of his reservations about theatre commands, saying it was "not a very good idea". "We, for now, don't need any new structure," he said, warning against disrupting the existing structure and suggesting instead the establishment of a joint planning and coordination centre to oversee integrated operations. According to insiders, the remarks effectively derailed the CDS's efforts that had included over 20 high-level meetings with the three services over the past two years to iron out differences.

The IAF has long expressed concerns that theatre commands could diminish its operational autonomy, divide and render ineffective its already depleted fighter squadrons and relegate it to a supporting role.

Backing the air chief, a serving air marshal says that theatre command in India will only "cause theatrics" without any advantage to national security. Indicating that the current system works just fine, he says: "CAS (chief of air staff) stated a fact. Was any jointness issue faced during Operation Sindoor, post the Balakot airstrike, or augmenting the army in the northern sector post the Galwan clashes?" Maj. Gen. Shashi Asthana (retd), director of the United Service Institution (USI), also questions drastic structural reforms, asking, "Since 1962, we haven't lost a war—so how can one claim the existing system is flawed?"

However, the air chief's doubts stood in stark contrast to the unified front presented by the army and navy. Army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi emphasised that theatre commands were essential for "executing all tasks during conflict". During the same seminar in Mhow, navy chief Admiral D.K. Tripathi stated that the navy remained fully committed to "theatrisation as the ultimate goal".

Some are frustrated that despite the government's announcement in 2019 to create ITCs and the appointment of two chiefs of defence staff to oversee it, little tangible progress has been made. "We've spent years in meetings, drafting

RINGS OF PROTECTION

The three proposed theatre commands cover our northern flanks, as well as the Indian Ocean Region

PAKISTAN-CENTRIC WESTERN THEATRE COMMAND

From Indira Col on Saltoro Ridge in the Siachen Glacier to Gujarat

HQ in Jaipur

CHINA-CENTRIC NORTHERN THEATRE COMMAND

Covers the entire 3,488 kilometres of Line of Actual Control, starting from the Karakoram Pass in Ladakh to Kibithu in Arunachal Pradesh

HQ in Lucknow

MARITIME COMMAND

Responsible for India's coastline of 7,516 km, as well as the Indian Ocean Region

HQ in Thiruvananthapuram

